

# Computational classification of SOD2 protein in coral and symbiotic algae from public genomic and transcriptomic data

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## ABSTRACT

SOD2, or Manganese/Iron Superoxide Dismutase, plays a crucial role in maintaining cellular health across the tree of life. Existing literature is vague in identifying types of SOD2 proteins expressed in both corals and their symbiotic algae; most agree on the presence of a) mitochondrial targeting MnSOD in corals, and b) likely Mn dependent SOD2 in algae. This paper presents evidence for four classes of SOD2 proteins between coral hosts and their symbiotic algae. Public genomic and transcriptomic data reveal mitochondrial targeting and secreted versions of SOD2 among a wide range of cnidaria species, and chloroplast targeting (with a bipartite leader architecture) and secreted versions of SOD2 among several symbiodinium species. The mature/catalytic region of SOD2 is well conserved within each class, but highly differentiated between classes. This paper presents the mature region HMM profiles for each class, with threshold scores high enough such that they are predictive of leader type.

## Introduction

SOD2 proteins protect cells against oxidative damage by converting toxic superoxide radicals into hydrogen peroxide and diatomic oxygen. SOD2 proteins can bind either manganese (MnSOD) or iron (FeSOD) as co-factors; their structure consists of conserved residues His26, His74, Asp159, and His163 (human sequence coordinates) forming the anchors of a trigonal bipyramidal metal pocket and variations in the outer shell, based on bound metal, to ensure superoxide dismutase activity [1]. SOD2 is present throughout tree of life, with bacterial SOD2 often preferring Fe as cofactor, mammalian SOD2 almost always requires Mn as a cofactor to function in mitochondria, and metal preference not always phylogenetically constrained [2].

Existing literature is vague on the types of SOD2 proteins in coral hosts and their symbiotic algae. While there is consensus on the presence of mitochondrial MnSOD in corals, other forms of SOD2 in coral and symbiotic algae are rarely discussed/analyzed separately. [3] reports experimental evidence for secreted superoxide dismutase activity in *Stylophora pistillata* without identifying the source of such activity. [4] experimentally identifies two forms of MnSOD in *Hydra vulgaris*, a non-coral species in the cnidaria phylum. [5] computationally compares various annotated MnSOD and FeSOD sequences from various symbiodinium species, with grouping of sequences, based on putative annotation, inconsistent with findings of this paper. Indeed, most transcriptomic analyses in the field depend on blasting against UniProt or NCBI, or matching against the HMM profile K04564, a pan-metagenomic KEGG ortholog ([6]) for SOD2. Neither approaches provide resolution beyond putative superoxide dismutase activity.

This paper presents results from an unbiased computational search and grouping of SOD2 protein sequences, using NCBI deposited genome sequences from 36 coral and 10 symbiodinium species, as well as RNAseq datasets from 5 papers. The goal of this work is to present specific and unambiguous sequence-level profiles for SOD2 proteins in *Anthozoa* and *Dinophyceae*. Although these protein groups have features that are suggestive of biological and biochemical mechanism, the scope of this paper is limited to computational;

**Table 1.** RNAseq sequences used in this paper

| Species                       | Source of Raw Reads | Source of Transcriptome | Source of Protein Sequences |
|-------------------------------|---------------------|-------------------------|-----------------------------|
| <i>Acropora tenuis</i>        | [14]                | This paper, Trinity     | This paper, TransDecoder    |
| <i>Orbicella faveolata</i>    | [15]                | This paper, Trinity     | This paper, TransDecoder    |
| <i>Pseudodiploria clivosa</i> | [15]                | This paper, Trinity     | This paper, TransDecoder    |
| <i>Siderastrea radians</i>    | [15]                | This paper, Trinity     | This paper, TransDecoder    |
| <i>Durusdinium trenchii</i>   | [16]                | [16]                    | This paper, TransDecoder    |
| <i>Cladocopium goreau</i>     | [14]                | This paper, Trinity     | This paper, TransDecoder    |
| <i>Breviolum B5</i>           | [15]                | This paper, Trinity     | This paper, TransDecoder    |
| <i>Breviolum faviinorum</i>   | [15]                | This paper, Trinity     | This paper, TransDecoder    |
| <i>Symbiodinium A3</i>        | [15]                | This paper, Trinity     | This paper, TransDecoder    |
| <i>Durusdinium trenchii</i>   | [17]                | This paper, Trinity     | This paper, TransDecoder    |
| <i>Cladocopium goreau</i>     | [18]                | [18]                    | This paper, TransDecoder    |

there is no experimental work, beyond referenced RNAseq experiments, to functionally validate the different classes of proteins, determine their metal preference, or likely cellular location.

Specifically, a protein sequence database was constructed from a) protein sequences submitted to and associated with NCBI genome accessions, b) protein sequences exhaustively detected using 25k+ KO HMM profiles ([6]) on 6-frame translations of genomic sequences submitted to and associated with NCBI genome accessions, and c) protein sequences generated from transcriptomes from 5 published RNAseq studies. 210 seed sequences meeting the K04564 HMM profile minimum threshold ([7]) were selected from this sequence database.

Seed sequences were further filtered to those containing PF00081 and PF02777 Pfam FeSOD N and C-terminal domains, using Pfam's gathering score ([8]), and having four key metal binding pocket residues ([1]). A *mature protein sequence* between (inclusive) the 3rd AA of PF00081 and 100th AA of PF02777 was extracted for each remaining seed sequence.

A leader discovery algorithm was employed to look for, in predicted exons if protein sequence was obtained through a gene model (above (a)) or in upstream 3-frame translations (above (b)) or in the protein sequence (above (c)), possible start codons upstream of each mature protein sequence. This algorithm produced zero (if no suitable start codon was found) or more full length SOD2 sequences for each mature sequence. This leader discovery step typically found predicted start sites for coral hosts, but was instrumental in finding complete SOD2 sequences in symbiotic algae genomic and transcriptomic data; tandom transcription ([9]) and alternative splicing sites ([10]) make gene prediction in dinoflagellates difficult otherwise. More on all of these in the Methods section below.

DeepLoc 2.1 ([11]) was used to determine possible target cellular compartment and leader type of each full length SOD2 sequence. MUSCLE multi-sequence alignments ([12]) was used to group mature protein sequences.

Five RNAseq studies are included in this work. Table 1 lists the papers and the dataset each contributes. RNAseq data provides further evidence for expression, and works around the complex splicing machinery in symbiodinium. In some cases, raw reads from the original paper were obtained from NCBI and assembled using Trinity ([13]) into a transcriptome, and TransDecoder ([13]) was used to generate protein sequences.

## Results

Manual inspection of DeepLoc 2.1 results over full length SOD2 sequences suggests the presence of three patterns: a) a mitochondrial transit peptide (mTP) between 15 to 35 AAs upstream of PF00081 with sequence location predicted to be mitochondria, b) a signal peptide (SP) between 15 to 40 AAs upstream of PF00081

**Table 2.** Breakdown of full length SOD2 sequences

| Group        | Taxonomy     | DeepLoc Predictions |                 | Start codon upstream of PF00081 | Unique full length seqs |
|--------------|--------------|---------------------|-----------------|---------------------------------|-------------------------|
|              |              | Leader              | Location        |                                 |                         |
| mT_cnidaria  | Coral        | mTP                 | Mitochondria    | 15 to 35 AAs                    | 65                      |
| SP_cnidaria  | Coral        | SP                  | Extracellular   | 15 to 40 AAs                    | 35                      |
| SP_cTP_algae | Symbiodinium | SP                  | Golgi apparatus | 50 to 70 AAs                    | 17                      |
| SP_algae     | Symbiodinium | SP                  | Extracellular   | 15 to 35 AAs                    | 6                       |

with sequence location predicted to be extracellular, and c) a signal peptide between 50 and 70 AAs upstream of PF00081 with sequence location predicted to be the golgi apparatus. Specifically, the first and last predictions were almost exclusively for coral hosts and symbiodiniums, respectively, while the middle prediction includes sequences for both hosts and symbionts.

Additional inspection using DeepLoc, on the SP and golgi apparatus sequences, reveal that once the SP is cleaved, DeepLoc predicts the remaining sequence as plastid bound. This observation is consistent with general consensus of bipartite leader architecture for chloroplast targeting proteins in cells that have gone through secondary endosymbiosis [19].

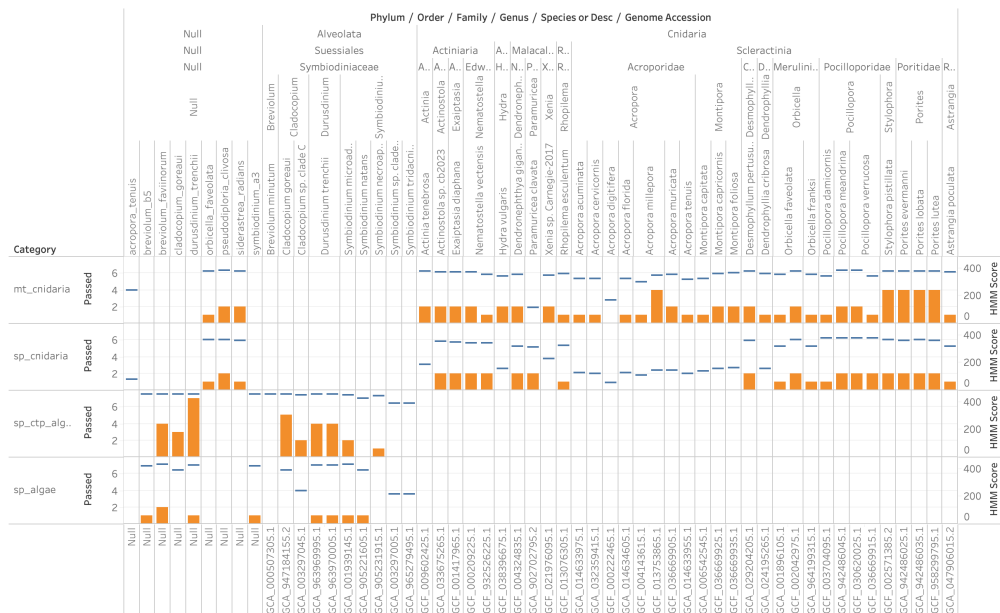
Based on these observations, leader discovery algorithm was adjusted to specifically look for start sites in these ranges, and the full length SOD2 sequences were separated into four groups: mTP in coral, SP in coral, SP+golgi in symbiodinium, and SP in symbiodinium. Multi-sequence alignments of mature protein sequences within each bucket showed high degree of conservation. Overall, 147 full length SOD2 sequences, 123 unique, exhibited these DeepLoc called features. Table 2 shows the breakdown by group. Figure 1 shows breakdown by taxonomy – the first columns on the left are transcriptomic sequences, then the rest of the columns are grouped by taxonomy of the genomic sequences.

#### **Four groups of SOD2 sequences, two in coral and two in symbiodinium, are clearly distinguishable from each other, and covers >90% of sequences with SOD2 signature**

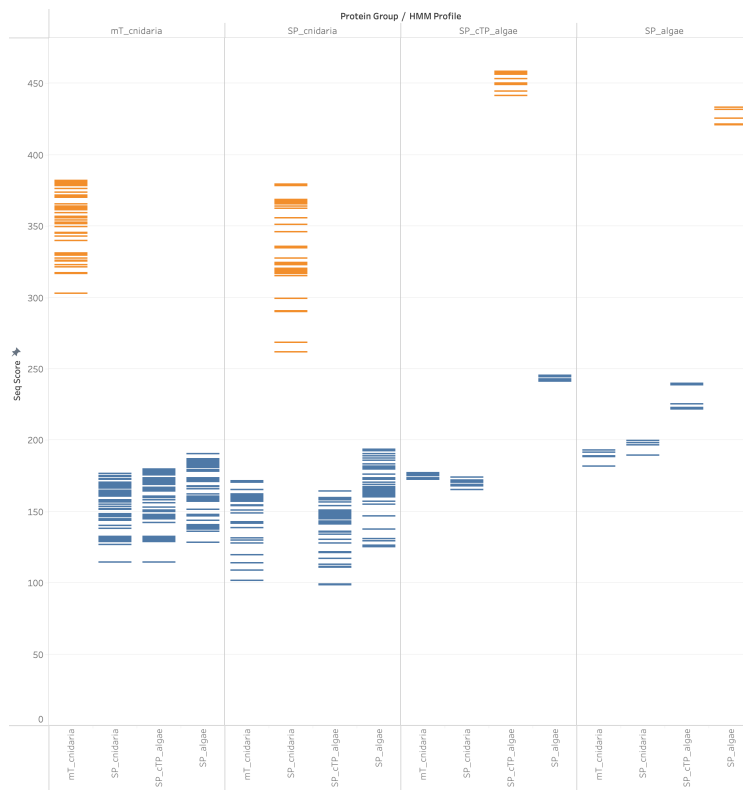
For each protein group, a HMM profile of the mature protein sequences was constructed using hmmer3 ([20]). Figure 2 shows that the four HMM profiles are clearly distinguishable; when scoring each group against all four profiles, the correct profile, in orange, scores the highest, with no overlap with other scores. The lowest score from each set of orange marks is used as the "threshold score" for the corresponding HMM profile. The values are 303.5, 262.4, 441.8, and 421.3, respectively.

To test if there are other undiscovered SOD2 protein groups, 114 unique mature protein sequences were selected from all the genomic and RNAseq sequences that matched to the K04564 HMM profile, without checking for plausible start codons, types of leader sequences, and targeted cellular compartment. These 114 sequences were then scored against the HMM profiles from the four groups. All but 12 sequences scored above the threshold for a HMM profile. Out of the 12 negatives, 4 are just below the threshold for SP\_cTP\_algae and can be considered FNs. The remaining 8, or 7% are unknown sequences. Thus, the four HMM profiles are able to cover 93% of all K04564 matching sequences in this paper's datasets.

Interestingly, SP\_cnidaria sequences are missing from all the genomes under the *Acroporidae* family. The *Acropora tenuis* RNAseq data from [14] was captured against its genomic sequences, which may also explain the lack of a SP\_cnidaria sequence in that transcriptome. It is unclear if this omission in the genome is real, or due to some genome assembly artifact.



**Figure 1.** Orange vertical bars are the numbers of full length SOD2 sequences per species/genome, for each of the four protein groups. Left columns are sequences from RNAseq studies. Right columns include sequences from genomes, grouped by taxonomy. Horizontal marks are the highest HMM scores from each set of sequences, scored against the HMM profile for that protein group. A high HMM score without accompanying orange vertical bar indicates a false negative – a protein sequence can be classified by HMM into a group, but DeepLoc is unable to predict the required leader type and/or compartment.



**Figure 2.** hmmsearch scores of protein groups (each in a pane), against all the HMM profiles (columns).

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## **RNAseq data provides expression evidence for all but SP\_algae**

XXX tx counts from PM34 XXX sp\_algae may not express? but RNAseq data cannot confirm these because most are single timepoint and condition

What's missing? Acropora and sp\_cnidaria?

## **The four groups of SOD2 proteins form distinct clades in an unrooted phylogenetic tree, suggesting independent evolution**

160 mature SOD2 sequences consisting of the 123 from coral and symbiodinium, plus 37 from annotated reference SOD2 proteins from across the tree of life, were clustered (98% sequence similarity) using MMSeqs ([21]), aligned using MUSCLE, and organized into an unrooted phylogenetic tree using IQTree ([22]).

Figure 3 shows the tree as visualized using iTOL ([23]). Each of the four protein groups forms an exclusive clade that includes every member of the group and shares a unique common ancestor. This tree structure suggests these four groups evolved independently, without intermixing with each other. Additionally, the mature protein sequences co-evolved, in lockstep, with the localization signals.

## **Discussion**

### **Independent evolution of the four protein groups**

Figure 3 strongly suggests that mT\_cnidaria is the canonical mitochondrial MnSOD protein, clustered with reference primate and fungal mitochondrial targeting MnSOD sequences with the enclosing fungal node supported by a branch bootstrap score of 100. Likely, mT\_cnidaria evolved from the endosymbiosis event that gave rise to the eukaryotic mitochondria.

In contrast, SP\_cnidaria appears to have evolved distantly from mT\_cnidaria, likely independent of mitochondrial endosymbiosis.

More sequences would boost confidence of any interpretation of the grouping of SP\_algae and SP\_cTP\_algae in the tree. Currently, these two distinct groups appear to be paralogs that have come from gene duplication events.

### **Unverified metal specificity for three protein groups**

mT\_cnidaria is likely a canonical mitochondrial MnSOD. While there are no direct experimental evidence of manganese specificity of coral mitochondrial SOD2, this specificity has been demonstrated experimentally in other species [24].

Assigning metal specificity for the other three protein groups cannot be done computationally. Metal co-factor preference of a SOD2 protein does not always correlate with sequence; specificity depends on several non-conserved second sphere residues around the metal binding pocket, different from the key structural residues this paper used to filter for functional SOD2 sequences. Additionally, while some proteins are Mn or Fe dependent, others are cambialistic and can work with either ion.

The metal annotations for the reference sequences in Figure 3 come from UniProt and are provided as a reference. Many of these annotations may not have been experimentally validated.

### **Unverified cellular compartment for three protein groups**

The final destination of the SP\_cnidaria, SP\_cTP\_algae, and SP\_algae (if expressed) proteins have not been proven experimentally. While there are some evidence for secreted SOD2 activity in literature [4] [3], there is no link, yet, between those activity and sequence.



Figure 3. Sample figure caption.

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The leader type in these three groups come from DeepLoc [11]. To sanity check DeepLoc predictions, XXX Should be secreted, using K09490 (ER chaperone) as control: sequences from various species fall into two groups, one had SP+ER DeepLoc call, the other NLS+Cytoplasm. Stripping out the SP, DeepLoc does not by default report Plastid but reports ER and Cytoplasm as localization, and NLS, NES, and SP as signals. Should be plastid, using K02639 (ferredoxin) as control: DeepLoc detected Golgi as localization, but SP was only called for some sequences not all even though the leader sequence appears to be highly conserved. Stripping out the SP, DeepLoc reports Plastid as the localization for the truncated protein.

### Disagreement with prior grouping

Results from this paper disagree with statements in [5], where protein sequences were grouped into MnSOD1, MnSOD2, and MnSOD3 groups. Sequences from MnSOD1 and MnSOD2 matched well with SP\_cTP\_algae, while some sequences from the MnSOD3 group scored above threshold for SP\_algae.

## Methods

HMM search of 6 frames needle

Classification of K04564 Classification of Pfam using gathering score heap coral

Trinity assembly and TransDecoder Counting using Salmon, for transcripts pile

AUGUSTUS challenge. Why leader discovery and bounding was important. Rules for functional enzyme - what residues Leader search in transcriptome and genomic data sieve

## Additional data

210 seed/input sequences - use this to screen all the HMM profiles, for the completeness section

The sequences TSV file so we know which genome they come from

Final list of all sequences that passed the rules and are used for alignment - this is the 123?

Final list of mature sequences from above - this is the 123?

Profiles and thresholds

Figure 2 tree inputs, 123 + 37 reference sequences, then clustered

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